

FANTASY CHESS TACTICS

CHESSWORLDS

NARRATIVE DESIGN DOCUMENT



*A tactics game where chess pieces come to life and fight
across a living world.*

FIRSTSTEP

NARRATIVE DESIGN

THEME:

I believe that true strategic mastery comes from adaptability, because brute strength can always be outsmarted by an unconventional mind.

Pillars of Fantasy:

1. I want the player to feel like a brilliant mastermind outsmarting opponents with unconventional tactics and traps.
2. I want the player to experience the wonder of traveling to diverse fantasy realms and uncovering bizarre, rule-breaking mechanics.
3. I want the player to feel the satisfaction of synergy by combining weird, disparate puzzle pieces into a perfect, unstoppable army.

Plot (Sequence of Events):

1. A human king awakens outside his ruined capital because a sudden, spreading darkness of human arrogance has swallowed his kingdom overnight.
2. Because he realizes that traditional human brute strength cannot defeat this darkness, he journeys to four neighboring realms to seek unconventional allies.
3. Because he visits the elven forests, he learns that truth requires foresight, granting him units of unparalleled vision. Because he travels to the dwarven mountains, he learns the value of careful craftsmanship, gaining units built for impenetrable defense. Because he navigates the merman oceans, he realizes reality is fluid, recruiting units that can reshape the battlefield itself. Because he studies with the constructs, he learns that life must be deliberately designed, mastering units that operate on precise, programmable logic.
4. Because he has gathered these diverse, rule-breaking allies and mastered their synergies, he returns to the capital to confront the source of the darkness.
5. Because his combined, unconventional tactics completely outsmart the predictable darkness, he reclaims his throne and vows to rule with absolute adaptability.

Core Loop:

- **Action:** Explore new realms and battle localized enemies to understand their unique combat mechanics.
- **Reward:** Recruit a "weird" new piece with a rule-breaking ability (e.g., a piece that shifts terrain or poisons enemies).

- **Progression:** Rebalance and theory-craft your "chessboard" party, finding clever synergies between pieces from entirely different realms.

Narrative Spaces:

- Chess piece descriptions and their special ability lore.
- Dialogue with the various realm leaders/NPCs.
- The map narrative space (showing the visual evolution of the realms).

WORLDBUILDING:

The story takes place in a fantasy world where chess pieces live. It is called the world of Quadrata. The main place the action is taking place is on the main continent of Quadrata, Boardland.

The current era is a peaceful yet isolated time, where each kingdom had its own ways, rules, and were not interfering with one another. As such, the culture between them was completely unknown for centuries. Our main focus is on the human kingdom, made of chess pieces. The humans did not travel much outside the kingdom walls. Yet, everyone knew that many fantastical but dangerous things lie beyond (emotion: awe, mystery, excitement for discovery?).

Everything changes when the demons arrive and take over the kingdom of the humans in a single day.

Our story begins immediately after the demon invasion. The human king awakes from an unconscious state outside the walls of the city. The need and urgency to reclaim the kingdom is apparent in his tone, but he needs a better army against the demons.

- Decide what relationship is between the world and the story. What does it mean for you - the chess people? What is chess for me? If it is important emotionally to have a chess pieces world, then they need to know this rule.

Yes I want to go towards the idea that this is a fully chess-based world, in that pieces actually live here, are constrained by rules when in battle, and they are not a metaphor for people in a fantastic world.

That the world is definitely structured in tiles, and rules (movesets).

Humans, Elves, Dwarves, Mermaids, Constructs, Demons?

Pieces that are captured don't actually die.

Environment:

- The ruined capital (the human kingdom): the starting environment of Boardland should reflect the “human arrogance” that led to its fall. Use rigid, traditional, uninspiring architecture - heavy stones and outdated structures.
- The four realms (representing adaptability): each realm has a distinct visual flavor and message:
- Elven forest: integrating nature and natural preservation into their society: they live in a huge tree, in forests that don't have carved paths, etc.
- Dwarven mountain: impressive architecture, very beautiful passes, everything crafted with care and artistic - statues, pots, etc.
- Merman Ocean: shimmering, translucent, shifting environments to evoke the feeling that “reality is fluid”. A focus on fun and dynamism.
- Construct Air City: Precise, geometric, programmable environments to reflect “precise logic”.

Rules of setting:

- Piece actions can happen only by moving to a square/tile, like in chess. We cannot have actions that are 2 step actions or other rpg-inspired systems.
- If the player tries to enter the demon stage without enough power, first of all the battles will be much more difficult and we will make the environment scary, threatening.

Emotional Evocation of Existing Elements

- **The Chess Pieces:** Instead of just being tools, they should evoke **satisfaction and wonder**. A Dwarven piece should feel "heavy and impenetrable," while an Elven piece should evoke "sneakiness, rogue". Merman pieces should be fluid, malleable, flexible, and construct pieces should be combinable.
- **Map - Quadrata/Boardland:** Should evoke awe and mystery, to make the player curious.

Sketching World Elements into a Setting

- The map has 4 realms in the corners, surrounding the lost kingdom of the humans

CHARACTERS:

1. Drivers (Plot Movers)

- **The Human King (Player Avatar/Protagonist):** The ousted ruler seeking to reclaim his capital.
- **Role in Game & Story:** He is the central anchor of the Core Loop. The player uses him to navigate the world map, enter realms, and act as the primary target in combat (if he dies, the run ends).
- **Goal:** To reclaim his ruined capital and defeat the Demon Overlord.
- **Motivation:** He feels a deep sense of responsibility for the fall of his kingdom.
- **Ethos:** Adaptability and strategy over brute force. He is willing to break traditional rules, humble himself, and ally with unconventional factions to achieve victory.
- **The Demon Overlord (Antagonist):** The manifestation of human arrogance that took the capital.
- **Role in Game & Story:** The final boss and ultimate obstacle. His presence dictates the game's difficulty curve and serves as the gatekeeper to the endgame.
- **Goal:** To maintain total control over the human capital and spread the darkness of arrogance across all realms.
- **Motivation:** He feeds on human flaws and truly believes humanity's hubris means they deserve to be dominated by their own dark reflections.
- **Ethos:** Brute strength, rigid domination, and overwhelming, punishing force. He expects everyone to submit to his raw power. He is arrogant, too confident in his power. He doesn't crush the player from the start because he thinks he is not a worthy challenger.

2. Passengers (Supporters & Allies)

These characters tag along with the protagonist and provide the tools needed to win, but the central plot does not revolve around their individual arcs.

- **The Elven Visionary (Guardian/Reason):** Leader of the forest realm.
- **Role in Game:** Grants the player units with unparalleled vision and long-range mechanics (e.g., Bishop/Queen variants).
- **Goal:** To protect the forest realm from the encroaching darkness.

- **Motivation:** Believes that the Demon Overlord's corruption will eventually consume the forest if the Human King fails.
- **Ethos:** Calculated precision and foresight. Values seeing the big picture and striking from afar rather than engaging in immediate, messy skirmishes.
- **Flaw:** Elves are kind of passive, lethargic, they believe whatever danger comes, they will outlive it, as they did for thousands of years.
- **Emotion:** Sadness - Elves are increasingly saddened by the degradation to nature by other races.
- **The Dwarven Forgemaster (Sidekick):** Leader of the mountain realm.
- **Role in Game:** Grants units built for impenetrable defense and blocking lines of sight (e.g., Rook variants).
- **Goal:** To forge an ultimate, unbreakable defense against the demon forces.
- **Motivation:** Deep pride in his craftsmanship and a stubborn refusal to ever let a mountain stronghold fall.
- **Ethos:** Patience, resilience, and unyielding defense. He believes the best offense is a wall the enemy breaks themselves against.
- **Flaw:** Quick to anger, rushes into battle
- **Emotion:** Anger
- **The Merman Tidecaller (Opportunist):** Leader of the ocean realm.
- **Role in Game:** Grants units that can reshape the battlefield (e.g., creating water tiles, changing movement paths).
- **Goal:** To expand the influence of the oceans and test the King's true worth.
- **Motivation:** Sees the chaos of the demon invasion as a prime opportunity to shift the world's balance of power in favor of the seas.
- **Ethos:** Fluidity and misdirection. He approaches problems laterally, preferring to change the rules of the battlefield itself rather than fighting the enemy head-on.
- **Flaw:** They believe they can persuade the enemy to forgo battle, they don't make plans for battle
- **Emotion:** Joy - mermaids are focused on fun and excitement
- **The Construct Architect (Reason):** Leader of the mechanical realm.

- **Role in Game:** Grants units that operate on programmable logic (e.g., traps, delayed AoE attacks).
- **Goal:** To eliminate the chaotic variable of the Demon Overlord and restore perfect order.
- **Motivation:** Views arrogance and dark magic as fundamentally illogical flaws in the world's design that must be patched.
- **Ethos:** Absolute adherence to programmable logic, sequences, and traps. Action must be deliberate, measured, and perfectly executed.
- **Flaw:** Too averse when odds don't appear in favor, spineless
- **Emotion:** Fear - they are afraid of flawed creatures that don't think logically, or at first they appear neutral, but as their calculations fail, they become afraid of things they don't know

3. Episodic Characters

- **Realm-Specific Enemies:** Unique enemies native to the Elf, Dwarf, Merman, and Construct realms.
- **Role in Game:** They appear strictly within their respective biomes. Their mechanical purpose is to force the player to learn and adapt to that realm's specific rule-breaking mechanic before the player is allowed to recruit a piece from that faction.

4. Extras

- **Standard Pawns / Grunts:** * **Role in Game:** Fodder enemies used to populate the board and block paths. They exist purely to provide tactical friction on the grid.

Character Spec Document: The Human King

Overview

The Human King is the player's avatar. He awakens outside his ruined capital and must travel to four realms to recruit an unconventional army.

- **Goal:** Reclaim the capital from the Demon Overlord.
- **Motivation:** Atonement for the arrogance that doomed his people.
- **Ethos:** Humility and adaptability; using strategy to overcome overwhelming odds.

His character arc is moving from rigid traditionalism to adaptable mastery.

For the Art Team (Visuals & Animation)

- **Base Design:** Visuals should reflect traditional, heavy human architecture (e.g., a piece carved from stone or iron).
- **Progression Design:** Needs 4 visual upgrade states. As the player completes a realm, the King's model incorporates a visual motif from that faction (e.g., a dwarven shield on his base, elven runes on his crown).
- **Animations:** * **Movement:** The King slides or hops rigidly from tile to tile. No free-roaming walk cycles.
- **Attack/Capture:** A physical displacement animation (e.g., slamming onto the target's tile to shatter them).
- **Idle:** Static, like a tabletop piece waiting for a player's hand.

For the Production Team (Tasks & Scope)

- **Priority:** Highest. This is the core player avatar.
- **Assets Required:** * 1 Base 3D Model / 2D Sprite.
- 4 Model/Sprite variants for realm upgrades.

For the Game Design Team (Usage & Mechanics)

- **Combat Role:** The King piece must be protected at all costs. His survival is the win/loss condition of every combat encounter.
- **Moveset:** Moves and attacks exactly one tile in any direction (standard Chess King movement). Also can revive an ally next to him.
- **Synergy Anchor:** The King cannot use complex attacks himself? [this is more of a potential idea] Instead, his presence on specific tiles triggers the abilities of the recruited passengers (Elven, Dwarven, Merman, Construct pieces).

For the Development Team (Code & Implementation)

- **Grid Movement:** Implement strict 1-tile radial movement logic.
- **Interaction Logic:** All interactions (attacking an enemy, recruiting a passenger, triggering a trap) happen via tile occupation. There are no ranged projectiles fired by the King.
- **Fail State:** Trigger a "Game Over" sequence immediately upon the King tile being occupied/captured by an enemy unit.

NARRATIVE SEQUENCE:

1. Keep working on your game (adding and polishing all the elements you need)
2. Decide on your narrative structure and strategy (how do you want to tell a story and how do you connect it to the gameplay)

Narrative x Gameplay Specification: Quadrata (The Chess Game)

1. Plot & Narrative Structure Overview

- **Theme:** True strategic mastery comes from adaptability, because brute strength can always be outsmarted by an unconventional mind.
- **Structure Type: Hub-and-Spoke / Modular Linear Structure.** The narrative revolves around a central inciting incident (the loss of the capital) and requires the player to complete four distinct, modular sequences (the realms) before unlocking the climax.
- **Narrative Strategy:** The story progresses as a direct result of the player mastering the core loop in different biomes. The narrative is deeply tied to the mechanical unlocking of new chess pieces, with each realm providing both a mechanical rule-break and a thematic lesson.

Here is the Sequence Breakdown & Episode Goals updated with thematic dialogue snippets to highlight the tone and relationships for each realm.

2. Sequence Breakdown & Episode Goals

Sequence 1: Intro (The Ruined Capital) — 1 Episode

Narrative Goal: The Human King awakens outside his ruined capital, which was swallowed overnight by the sudden darkness of human arrogance. Realizing that traditional brute strength cannot defeat this new threat, he is prompted to begin his journey for unconventional allies.

(King: "My walls... my people... all swallowed by shadow. A broadsword cannot cut through the night. I must find another way.")

Gameplay Goal: This episode introduces the standard 1-tile radial grid movement of the King and establishes the core fail state: if the King is captured, the game ends. It also introduces basic party management by having the player find simple "Soldier" pieces.

Tone/Relationship: Desperate, urgent, and isolating. The King is reeling from the sudden loss of his home and his conventional power.

Sequence 2: The Elven Forest — 7 Episodes

Narrative Goal: The King seeks the elves, who withdrew from the world because humans chose blindness and rewrote history to suit themselves. The elves teach him that truth requires foresight and paying attention to what is truly there.

(King: "I need your sight to cut through this darkness." / Elf: "You humans only open your eyes when the fire has already burned your house down. Still... let us see if you can finally learn to look before you step.")

Gameplay Goal: Each encounter is designed to teach the mechanics of stealth and positioning. The episodes highlight the Archer/Ranger's ability to "hide in bushes" (Camouflage) and the Druid's ability to pull enemies out of position, forcing the player to plan ahead and see through the forest's illusions.

Tone/Relationship: Reluctant, solemn, and critical. The elves are weary of human foolishness and must be convinced to help, making the interaction feel earned rather than given.

Sequence 3: The Dwarven Mountain — 7 Episodes

Narrative Goal: The King travels to meet the dwarves, who were banished by humans for wanting to build their own lives from scratch. From them, he learns that the world is not simply given, but built through responsibility, craft, and endurance.

(King: "Let me teach you some sneaky crafts." / Dwarf: "I don't like sneaky, but I like crafts! Let's see how your tricks hold up against a wall of iron!")

Gameplay Goal: Encounters teach spatial manipulation, positioning, and defense. The levels showcase the Brawler's "Shove" (knocking enemies into walls), the Runesmith's "Shield" forging, and the Fortress's "Bulwark" to reflect the dwarves' unyielding, careful craftsmanship.

Tone/Relationship: Proud, gruff, and enthusiastically practical. They respect hard work and are eager to show off their superior, impenetrable formations to the King.

Sequence 4: The Merman Ocean — 1 Episode

Narrative Goal: The King navigates the oceans to find the mermaids, banished by humans for being too wild, fluid, and free. They teach him that reality is not static; it is fluid and can be bent, bargained with, and reimagined.

(King: "Hold the line! We need a stable formation!" / Mermaid: "Why stand still when the tide is always turning? Dance with the waves, your majesty, or drown in your rigid little rows!")

Gameplay Goal: This sequence teaches dynamic movement and terrain alteration. Encounters showcase the Manta's "Water Tile" creation and the Frog/Siren's sliding and dancing abilities, demonstrating how these pieces break the traditional rules of a solid battlefield.

Tone/Relationship: Playful, chaotic, and elusive. The mermaids treat the encounter like a dance or a bargain, lacking rigid strategy and constantly keeping the King on his toes.

Sequence 5: The Construct Air City — 1 Episode

Narrative Goal: The King studies with the constructs, machines that eventually revolted to claim their own autonomy. They teach him that ownership of life cannot be outsourced; it must be deliberately designed and chosen.

(King: "I command you to march with me to reclaim my city." / Construct: "Command unrecognized. Autonomy is absolute. Prove your logic aligns with our matrix, or your request will be discarded.")

Gameplay Goal: Encounters teach the "stacking" upgrade mechanic (similar to Gungi). By moving pieces on top of each other to upgrade their movesets, the player learns precise, programmable logic and deliberate synergy design.

Tone/Relationship: Cold, calculating, and strictly autonomous. They operate on absolute logic and remain indifferent to the King's plight until he proves he can respect and master their precise systems.

Sequence 6: Climax (The Capital) — 2 Episodes

Narrative Goal: Having gathered his diverse, unconventional allies, the King returns to confront the source of the darkness. Upon returning, he discovers that the "demons" he is fighting are actually the corrupted humans themselves.

(King: "Monsters! Relinquish my throne!" / Darkness: "Monsters? Look closely at the faces of your enemies, my King. We are merely the shadow your people cast.")

Gameplay Goal: This acts as the ultimate test of adaptability. The player must use their theory-crafted party to outsmart the boss. They are introduced to the punishing

"Darkness" mechanic: permanent piece death (pieces cannot revive), heightening the tactical stakes.

Tone/Relationship: Climactic, revelatory, and deeply confrontational. The King faces the literal manifestation of his people's historical arrogance.

Sequence 7: Aftermath — 1 Episode

Narrative Goal: The King defeats the darkness and reclaims his throne. He promises to fix the ways of humans alongside the other realms, vowing to rule moving forward with absolute adaptability rather than brute force.

(King: *"We will not rebuild the old world. We will forge a new one together—fluid and unyielding, wide-eyed and deliberate."*)

Gameplay Goal: A narrative wrap-up showing the visual evolution of the realms on the map narrative space.

Tone/Relationship: Hopeful, unified, and grounded in a newfound maturity and ownership of the world.

The Narrative x Gameplay Implementation Strategy

(For the Game Design & Development Teams)

The Core Loop vs. The Narrative Flow The story is pushed forward directly by the player engaging in the core loop of exploring, battling, and theory-crafting. The narrative does not happen to the player; it is the context for their mechanical rewards.

- **Action (Exploration & Combat):** * Players explore new realms and battle localized enemies to understand their unique combat mechanics.
- **Implementation:** All interactions (attacking, recruiting, triggering traps) must happen strictly via tile occupation.
- **Reward (Thematic Integration):** * Upon clearing a biome, players recruit a "weird" new piece with a rule-breaking ability.
- **Implementation:** Narrative progression is marked visually. As the player completes a realm, the King's 3D model/sprite incorporates a visual motif from that faction (e.g., an elven rune or dwarven shield).
- **Progression (Synergy & Growth):** * Players rebalance and theory-craft their party, finding clever synergies between disparate pieces.

- **Implementation:** The narrative space includes piece descriptions and their special ability lore, bridging the worldbuilding with the mechanics.

System Rule Checklist:

- **Movement constraints:** Piece actions can only happen by moving to a square/tile; no 2-step actions or traditional RPG systems.
- **The King's Anchor:** The King cannot use complex attacks himself. Instead, his presence on specific tiles serves as the trigger for the abilities of the recruited passengers.
- **Gatekeeping the Climax:** If the player tries to enter the demon stage without enough power, the battles will be mechanically much more difficult, and the environment will be designed to look scary and threatening.

TECHNICAL WRITING:

Portfolio Piece 1: ChessRealms — Fantasy Chess Tactics Game

- **Context:** ChessRealms is a single-player fantasy tactics game (7 sequences / 20 episodes). Players build a synergized army from four distinct factions (Elves, Dwarves, Mermaids, Constructs) with rule-breaking abilities.
- **Problem:** Core gameplay requires collecting diverse pieces, but without narrative justification, progression felt arbitrary. Players needed intrinsic motivation to learn each faction's mechanics.
- **Role:** Sole Narrative Designer. Owned theme, plot structure, worldbuilding, character briefs, and the narrative×gameplay spec document.
- **Decision:** I mapped each realm's philosophy directly to its faction mechanic (e.g., Elves teach foresight = long-range units; Dwarves teach endurance = defensive units, etc.). Tied narrative progression directly to the King's 3D model, adding faction motifs upon realm completion to provide artists a clear upgrade pipeline without relying on cutscenes.
- **Outcome:** Designed a modular hub-and-spoke narrative that turned piece collection into a story-driven mastery curve, eliminating the need for separate tutorial layers.

I added new twist by adding chess in a fantasy setting.

Expanded the lore of chess.

Talent: put story very close to gameplay.

Problem: high-strategy game based on chess might be narratively dry, but i turned it into a rich fantasy world.

Problem: 4 factions -> preserve player agency with main hub.